



Key player: Keegan Petersen played a key role in South Africa's last Test series win over India, making scores of 62, 72, and 82 in four innings as it came from behind to take the series 2-1.

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century in the first Test. Former South African opener Alviro Petersen called it the finest from a sub-continental opener in South African conditions. The Karnataka batter-wicketkeeper is likely to feature in the middle order this time. Yashasvi Jaiswal, who scored a hundred on his Test debut in the West Indies, is expected to open.

The young left-hander will find the conditions much more challenging than most places, as will the likes of Shubman Gill, the likely No. 3, and Shreyas Iyer. One batter India will miss greatly is the counter-attacking Rishabh Pant, still recuperating from last year's car accident.

His stunning knock had set up India's greatest Test win — against Australia at the Gabba in 2020-21 —

and he had made a glorious hundred that helped India build its lead in the final Test against South Africa on the last tour.

Mohammed Shami's late withdrawal — he hasn't recovered from his ankle injury — is a big blow.

In the ODI series against Australia and then in the World Cup, after being overlooked early on, he was a raging tempest. Imagine how effective he would have been in the far more helpful conditions of South Africa, where he was India's leading wicket-taker in 2021-22; he took eight in the Test win.

However, Jasprit Bumrah and Mohammed Siraj could ensure the South African batters do not breathe easy. Prasidh Krishna may come in place of Shami; the Karnataka quick did not harm his chances with a five-wicket haul in the first unofficial Test between South Africa-A and India-A in Potchefstroom, and Shardul Thakur's best Test innings figures (seven for 61) came on the previous tour. Spin hasn't traditionally been as effective in

South Africa as pace, but India has two of the world's best tweakers, R. Ashwin and Ravindra Jadeja.

Meanwhile, the home team is grappling with injuries, with Anrich Nortje already ruled out. Additionally, there are concerns about key players Kagiso Rabada and Lungi Ngidi, as per reports from South Africa. So the host might have to depend more on the young pace duo of Gerald Coetzee — a genuine quick and great prospect for the future — and Marco Jansen, the tall left-armer who has made rapid strides since making his debut against India a couple of years ago.

South Africa will want the classy batter Keegan Petersen to continue from where he left off against India; he was the Player of the Series.

Besides Elgar and Bavuma, there is also the elegant Aiden Markram.

It should be a good contest between two well-matched sides on wickets that tend to produce absorbing cricket. Rohit's men will approach it believing they could conquer the final frontier this time.